LOWER SECONDARY ENGLISH LITERATURE · SEC 2 END-OF-YEAR EXAM

Sec 2 Literature Cheat Sheet

Built around the school's 2026 Sec 2 Literature EOY briefing. Section A: *Emily of Emerald Hill* by Stella Kon (intro to drama, context, impressions of Emily, relationships, the passage-based "dramatic" question, motherhood, role of women). Section B: unseen poetry with the 4-Quadrant Routine. Quotes come from the class notes, and every section has practice questions with model answers.

Drama & context

Section A · intro to drama (style), context (setting and atmosphere) · 6 topics

The paper at a glance (from the school briefing)

EXAM

SECTION	TEXT	MARKS	WHAT YOU DO
A	*Emily of Emerald Hill* (Stella Kon)	25	2 questions given. Choose **only 1**: an **essay** question *or* a **passage-based question** (2 parts, with a passage)
B	Unseen poetry	25	A **2-part question** on a poem you haven't seen (same format as WA3)

What to study for Section A ("Study everything!"):

TOPIC	AREA OF STUDY
Intro to drama	Style
Context	Setting and atmosphere
Impressions of Emily (Act 1 and Act 2)	Characterisation
Relationship between Emily and others	Characterisation
Passage-based question: dramatic	Style
Motherhood	Theme
Role of women in society	Theme

- **Marking is holistic**, using band descriptors (Lower Secondary Set Text, and Unseen Poetry). The whole answer is judged, so clear argument and well-explained quotes matter most
- **Quotes:** pick out and memorise quotes that support what you say about each character and theme (use your workbook)
- **Last year's paper (2025):** 1 hour 40 minutes, 50 marks in total, dark blue or black ink, no staples, highlighters or correction fluid/tape. Label each part clearly
- **Marks are deducted if you** use correction tape or fluid, write in pencil, or don't write the question number, e.g. (i), (ii)

Watch out: in Section A, do **not** try both questions. Pick one in the first 2 minutes and stick to it.

Intro to drama: style of a one-woman play

STYLE

- **Monodrama:** one actress plays Emily for the whole play. Every other character (husband, children, mother-in-law, servants, guests) is unseen. We only hear Emily's side of every conversation
- **Direct address:** Emily speaks to the audience as if we were her guests, friends or family. We are drawn in and become her listeners
- **Flashbacks and time shifts:** the play moves back and forth in time instead of telling the story in order

PART	TIME	WHAT WE SEE
Act 1 opens	1950	Emily at her peak: capable manager of the house, fond mother, society hostess
Act 1 flashback	1920s–1929	Her childhood and early marriage: how powerless and vulnerable she once was
Act 2 opens	late 1950s	Then flashes back to her "glory days" of the early 1930s
Act 2 returns	late 1950s	Cooking babi buah keluak; Kheong tries to break away; the family crisis
Final scene	old age	In modern Singapore her memory drifts free of time and rewrites the past as she wished it had been

Effect of the structure: like meeting a new friend, we learn Emily's story in pieces, and the most private details come last. We admire her first, then understand *why* she needs control, then see what it costs.

Watch out: because we only hear Emily, she is an **unreliable narrator**. Say "Emily claims..." or "Emily presents herself as..." when her version may not be the whole truth.

Context: setting and atmosphere

CONTEXT

- **Playwright:** Stella Kon, a Singaporean writer. She began the play in 1982 and it won first prize at the **1983 National Playwriting Competition**
- **First staged:** 1984 in Seremban, Malaysia (actress Leow Puay Tin), then at the 1985 Singapore Drama Festival with **Margaret Chan** as Emily
- **Inspiration:** Kon's grandmother, who lived in a house called Oberon on Emerald Hill. Kon said she was the model for Emily's *character*, but not for the events of her life
- **Setting:** Emily's big family house, Oberon, on **Emerald Hill** (off Orchard Road), from 1929 to Emily's old age in modern Singapore
- **Peranakan world:** Straits Chinese families who mixed Chinese and Malay culture: Baba Malay language, sarong kebaya, nyonya food, large households run by a matriarch
- It is often called Singapore's **most-staged play** and a landmark of Singapore theatre in English

SETTING	ATMOSPHERE IT CREATES
The grand house at Emerald Hill, full of guests, food and servants	wealth, pride, busy and lively; Emily is in charge
A big extended family under one roof (in-laws, cousins, children)	competitive and tense; everyone watches everyone
Emily's early married life	lonely and hostile: "So they tried to bully me but I didn't cry" (p. 11)
Hospital, empty house, old age in modern Singapore	sad, quiet, lonely; the old world is fading

> **USING CONTEXT IN AN ANSWER**
> Link it to a point, in one sentence: "In a 1930s Peranakan family, a wife's worth came from serving her husband's family, so Emily's careful pleasing of her mother-in-law is how she gains security and power."

Watch out: don't write a history paragraph. One sentence of context, tied to the question, is enough.

Plot in order (what really happened)

PLOT

1. **Childhood:** Emily's father dies. When she is about 10, her mother leaves her, complaining that she has only a "useless" daughter and no son. Emily is passed between relatives
2. **1929, age 14:** she marries her cousin **Kheong**, about twice her age, and moves into the wealthy Gan household at Oberon, Emerald Hill
3. **Winning the house:** she pleases her mother-in-law (making tea, preparing betel leaves, massaging her at card games) and is rewarded with a diamond ring. Step by step she takes over running the household
4. **Matriarch and hostess:** by the 1930s–1950s she is a famous hostess and the real power in the family. Children: **Richard** (eldest, her favourite), Edward, Charlie and **Doris**
5. **Kheong drifts away:** her husband has a mistress, Diana Lee, and stays at her house. Emily still sends him food (p. 39), then exposes him (p. 40). When he is in hospital he refuses to see her (pp. 43–44)
6. **Richard:** Emily plans his future for him ("I have written to a college in London for you", p. 17). In England he wants to give up his studies and work at a riding school; Emily immediately phones the riding school to stop him. Unable to live the life she has planned for him, Richard takes his own life
7. **Doris:** wants to marry an American, Steve Jackson. This time Emily lets her go: she has learnt that love means letting go
8. **Old age:** on Charlie's advice she sells most of the Emerald Hill land (p. 52). Nieces and nephews still visit "the old auntie" (p. 49). Alone in a changed Singapore, she remembers and rewrites her past

Watch out: the play does not show these in this order (see Form and structure). In an essay, refer to moments by what happens ("when Emily goes to London..."), not by page number.

Peranakan culture and language in the play

CULTURE

WORD OR DETAIL	MEANING	WHY IT MATTERS
Nyonya / Baba	Peranakan woman / man	Emily's identity as a proud nyonya
Baba Malay	Peranakan language mixing Malay and Hokkien	Emily switches between English and Baba Malay: shows her world and her many roles
Sarong kebaya	traditional embroidered blouse and sarong	costume that marks her status and tradition
Babi buah keluak	pork cooked with black keluak nuts	Emily's cooking shows skill and control; food is how she wins love and loyalty
Sireh (betel leaves)	chewed by older nyonyas	preparing it for her mother-in-law shows how she pleases those with power
The house, Oberon	big family home on Emerald Hill	her kingdom: the space she controls

- Food, festivals, clothes and family rules show a **traditional world that is fading** by the end, as Singapore modernises and her children look to the West

Watch out: don't just list cultural details. Say what each one shows about Emily (status, control, love, change).

Drama terms to use in answers

TERMS

TERM	MEANING	EXAMPLE IN *EMILY*
Monologue / monodrama	one character speaks; one-actor play	the whole play
Direct address	character speaks straight to the audience	Emily treats us as guests and confidants
Flashback	scene set earlier in time	childhood, early marriage, the 1930s
Dramatic irony	audience knows more than the character	we see her control pushing Richard away before she does
Characterisation	how a writer builds a character	Emily's commands, flattery and boasting
Tone	the feeling in how something is said	bossy, charming, proud, bitter, regretful
Props and stage directions	objects and instructions for performance	food, the diamond ring, her kebaya
Foreshadowing	hint of what will come	her need to control hints at the loss of Richard

Watch out: naming a term earns nothing on its own. Always add its **effect**: "The direct address makes the audience feel like Emily's confidants, so we sympathise with her even when she is manipulative."

Characterisation Section A · impressions of Emily, relationships with others · 6 topics

Impressions of Emily: Act 1

ACT 1

In Act 1 we meet Emily at the height of her power, in her own home.

IMPRESSION	EVIDENCE	WHAT IT SHOWS
Sociable, welcoming	"Mr Chan, fill up your plate, Mr Chee, try a bit of sambal" (p. party scene)	a warm, confident hostess who talks easily to everyone
Commanding	"After all in six weeks you will have gone to England and you will lose touch with him anyway" (p. 6); then orders her servant Ah Hoon around	she takes charge of everyone, even her children's friendships
Responsible, organised	"So I keep myself busy, running the household, looking after all the family" (p. 7); plans the new bathrooms	she takes her duties seriously and plans in detail
Manipulative	New Year (p. 34): her father-in-law says they need not kneel, but she insists "I want to kneel down", so the others must kneel to her and Kheong	she plays the obedient "little girl" to gain authority over the family
Socially skilled	wishes tailored to each listener: business for her father-in-law, grandchildren and good cards for her mother-in-law; "You must bring little Emily"	she reads people well and uses it
Proud	huge meals, fine cutlery, the family's standing	she wants to impress and keep up the family name
Resilient (in flashback)	"So they tried to bully me but I didn't cry: I never cried for myself" (p. 11)	she survived a hard start; we start to sympathise

> **HOW TO WORD AN IMPRESSION**
> Use 2–3 precise adjectives, then evidence and explanation: "Emily comes across as commanding. She tells Richard that in six weeks he 'will lose touch with him anyway' (p. 6), deciding his friendships for him, which shows she expects her word to be final."

Watch out: "hardworking and responsible" with no quote was marked as **vague** in class. Always add a quote and say what it shows.

Impressions of Emily: Act 2

ACT 2

In Act 2 her control is tested, and we see her change.

IMPRESSION	EVIDENCE	WHAT IT SHOWS
Controlling, strict	"Richard, you better listen to my advice." (p. 25); she immediately phones the riding school when Richard says he will give up his studies	she puts her plans above her son's wishes
Enraged, frustrated	"I've had enough of his nonsense." (p. 40)	her patience with Kheong and Diana Lee breaks
Loyal, still caring	"But I send him special food from day to day" (p. 39); "Kheong! Kheong! Which ward is he in?" (p. 43)	she keeps her duty as a wife, even when he no longer loves her
Hurt, vulnerable	"What do you mean, he doesn't want to see me…" (p. 44)	the powerful matriarch is rejected; we pity her
Changed, receptive	"live your own life" (p. 48), "make your own decisions" (p. 48)	after Richard's death she learns to let go

Moments of change the 2025 marking guide accepted: her conversation with Doris (pp. 46–48); accepting that Kheong won't see her (p. 44); her talk with Susie (pp. 51–52); taking Charlie's advice to sell (p. 52). Higher-ability: forcing Kheong to give up Diana (p. 40) shows her manipulation *intensifying* when her marriage, the base of her power, is threatened.

The big shift: from a woman who controls everyone (Act 1) to one who is rejected, grieves, and learns to listen (Act 2).

Watch out: an answer on "impressions" should show **change**. Contrast Act 1 with Act 2 rather than listing traits from one act only.

Emily and Kheong (husband)

RELATIONSHIP

	WORDS TO DESCRIBE IT	EVIDENCE AND EXPLANATION
Beginning	distant, cordial	"I expected the father to bring him to see the Headmaster" (p. 14): Kheong "couldn't be bothered" with his children, so Emily does everything alone. "My husband didn't know" (p. 11): she hides her hard work from him and he only asks "Emily you're all right ah?" (p. 11). Polite, but not close
End	one-sided, tense, strained	"he's staying with his mistress's house" (p. 39) yet "But I send him special food from day to day" (p. 39): she keeps her duty though he has left her. "I've had enough of his nonsense." (p. 40): tension explodes and she exposes him. "Kheong! Kheong! Which ward is he in? Is he awake now? Can I talk to him?" (p. 43) → "What do you mean, he doesn't want to see me…" (p. 44): she still cares, he refuses her. Only Emily is trying

Watch out: don't call the marriage simply "bad". Use precise words (distant, cordial, one-sided, strained) and show how it **changes**.

Emily and her children

RELATIONSHIP

	WORDS TO DESCRIBE IT	EVIDENCE AND EXPLANATION
Beginning	controlling, suffocating, strained, one-sided	"I have written to a college in London for you to study there next year" (p. 17): she decides Richard's future without asking him. "you will do everything that I want you to do" (p. 17): the children can't disagree. "Richard, you better listen to my advice." (p. 25): "you better" sounds threatening. Stage direction: *she laughs as Richard flatters her* (p. 5): Emily believes they are close, but this is only how *she* sees it
End	caring, warm, receptive, more open about feelings	"I don't forbid you to get married" (p. 48), "live your own life" (p. 48), "make your own decisions" (p. 48): she lets Doris marry and live in America. She tells a tenant she can't renew his lease (p. 49) so Doris's family will have a home in Singapore. "I took his advice and sold the land" (p. 52): she now listens to Charlie

Why she changes: Richard's death. She doesn't want to make the same mistake of being too controlling again.

Watch out: compare **Richard** (held too tightly → tragedy) with **Doris** (let go → a warmer bond). This contrast is the heart of the motherhood theme.

Emily and her brothers- and sisters-in-law

RELATIONSHIP

	WORDS TO DESCRIBE IT	EVIDENCE AND EXPLANATION
Beginning	hostile, competitive, tense	"So they tried to bully me but I didn't cry: I never cried for myself" (p. 11): as a young bride she was picked on. "You tell them lah, they must show respect for their brother lah..." (p. 34): as wife of the eldest son, Kheong, she uses her status to make them show respect. "What was Freddy's position?" (p. 36): she competes with Susie over their sons' grades, pleased when Richard beats Freddy
End	caring, loving, on good terms	Her conversation with Susie (pp. 51–52) shows she no longer sees her as competition. "Well, how's your mother?" (p. 49): she asks after the family. "Now and again the children come to call on me, and Mabel's children and Molly's children come to visit the old auntie" (p. 49): the families hold no grudge and send their children to visit

Watch out: the in-laws show the theme of **status**: Emily moves from bullied newcomer to the most powerful woman in the family, then to a respected "old auntie".

Who's who (all unseen)

CHARACTER

CHARACTER	WHO	WHAT THEY SHOW ABOUT EMILY
Kheong	husband (and cousin), eldest son of the family	her striving pushes him away; he turns to his mistress Diana Lee
Richard	eldest son, her favourite	her love becomes control; his death is the play's tragedy
Doris	daughter, studies and marries in America	Emily learns to let go
Charlie (and Edward)	younger sons	Charlie's advice to sell the land shows Emily now listens
Father-in-law (Mr Gan Eng Swee)	English-educated head of the family; doubled its fortune and built Emerald Hill	Emily flatters him and uses his authority (New Year kneeling scene)
Mother-in-law	head of the house when Emily arrives	Emily learns power by pleasing her, then takes her place
Emily's mother	leaves Emily as a child	source of Emily's insecurity; sons valued over daughters
Joo Chong, Susie, Mabel, Molly	brother- and sisters-in-law (Freddy is Susie's son)	rivalry and status in the extended family
Diana Lee	Kheong's mistress	a threat to Emily's position as wife
Ah Hoon	servant	Emily's authority over the household

Because one actress plays everything through Emily's voice, we only ever get **Emily's version** of these people.

Watch out: spell the names right: **Kheong**, **Doris**, **Richard**, and the playwright **Stella Kon** ("Kon" in essays, not "Stella").

Themes Section A · motherhood, role of women in society · 3 topics

Motherhood

THEME

Kon shows that a mother's love can turn into control, and that real love means **letting go**.

POINT	EVIDENCE
Emily was an unloved daughter: her own mother left her, calling her a useless daughter because she wasn't a son	"I only have a useless girl like you. What were you born for?" (pp. 44–45)
Motherhood gives Emily purpose and power: she runs her children's lives	"So I keep myself busy, running the household, looking after all the family" (p. 7)
Love becomes control: she plans Richard's future and silences him	"I have written to a college in London for you" (p. 17); "you will do everything that I want you to do" (p. 17); "Richard, you better listen to my advice." (p. 25)
The cost: Richard can't live his own life, and his death is the play's tragedy	the riding school; his death
A better kind of mothering: she lets Doris choose, and quietly makes sure she has a home	"live your own life" (p. 48); "make your own decisions" (p. 48); the lease (p. 49)

> **MODEL TOPIC SENTENCE**
> "Kon presents motherhood as a powerful but dangerous love: Emily's devotion to Richard turns into control, and only after losing him does she learn to let Doris 'live [her] own life' (p. 48)."

Watch out: don't just say Emily is a "bad mother". Show **why** she controls (her own childhood, her need to be needed) and how she **changes**.

Role of women in society

THEME

Kon shows a society where a woman's worth comes from being a **wife and mother**, and how Emily wins power inside those limits. This was the 2025 EOY essay question.

POINT	EVIDENCE
Girls were seen as burdens, valued only through marriage and motherhood	"Why am I so unlucky, I don't have a son to take care of me? I only have a useless girl like you. What were you born for?" (pp. 44–45) "We took you out of the gutter, when your mother threw you away." (pp. 44–45)
Women were limited to the home	"a woman must look after her husband" (p. 16, to Molly) "when you get married you must know how to cook and look after your family" (p. 17, to Doris)
Emily sees the rules clearly	"a woman is nothing in this world that men have made, except in the role that men demand of her" (pp. 44–45) "Your life is meaningless, you have no value, except as you are a wife and mother" (pp. 44–45): so she chooses to be "the very devil of a wife and mother"
But power came through the home: Peranakan households were run by the matriarch	Emily runs the house and decides for everyone (pp. 16–17); controls Richard's friends (p. 5) and career (pp. 24–25), Doris's dancing (p. 15) and reading (p. 17)
Status came from her husband	"they must show respect for their brother lah" (p. 34); pressures Kheong to give up Diana (p. 42)
Double standard: Kheong keeps a mistress; Emily must still do her duty	"But I send him special food from day to day" (p. 39)
Changing times: Doris chooses her own life	"make your own decisions" (p. 48)

> **HIGHER-ABILITY POINT (FROM THE 2025 MARKING GUIDE)**
> Once her basic needs are met, Emily's choices come from **ambition, not necessity**: "We could buy shares… in future those shares will be very valuable" (p. 16); "Councillor Gan Joo Kheong – it sounds very good" (p. 17); she "sweeps forward magnificently to greet her guests" (p. 19); Richard "should have gotten the biggest share of the property" (p. 37); the Singapore Free Press reports their "splendidly-attended dinner" (p. 43).

For top marks: discuss Emily's relationships with **other women**, especially those above her (her mother-in-law), and write about the role of women *in general*, not only Emily.

Watch out: the marking guide says weaker answers talk only about Emily as a character. Keep linking back to **women in that society**.

Other themes (useful links)

THEMES

THEME	WHAT KON SHOWS	LINKS TO
Power and control	a powerless girl gains power by pleasing, then managing, everyone; control brings success but ruins relationships	role of women; motherhood
Identity and roles	Emily plays many parts: daughter-in-law, hostess, matriarch, mother, "old auntie"	role of women
Loneliness and the cost of success	Kheong leaves, Richard dies, the house is sold	motherhood; relationships
Tradition and change	the Peranakan world fades; children choose England and America; the land is sold	setting and atmosphere
Memory	Emily retells, and sometimes rewrites, her own past	style (monologue, flashback)

Watch out: the EOY briefing names **motherhood** and **role of women in society**. Use these other themes to support those two, not instead of them.

Emily: exam answers Section A · quotes, essay, passage-based question · 5 topics

Quote bank (from class notes) QUOTES

Short quotes to memorise, grouped by what they prove. Page numbers are from the class notes; check the wording in your own copy.

USE FOR	QUOTE
Commanding, controlling	"you will do everything that I want you to do" (p. 17) "Richard, you better listen to my advice." (p. 25) "I have written to a college in London for you to study there next year" (p. 17)
Responsible, busy hostess	"So I keep myself busy, running the household, looking after all the family" (p. 7) "Mr Chan, fill up your plate, Mr Chee, try a bit of sambal"
Hard start, resilience	"So they tried to bully me but I didn't cry: I never cried for myself" (p. 11) "My husband didn't know" (p. 11)
Role of women	"a woman must look after her husband" (p. 16) "when you get married you must know how to cook and look after your family" (p. 17) "a woman is nothing in this world that men have made, except in the role that men demand of her" (pp. 44–45)
Ambition, status	"Councillor Gan Joo Kheong – it sounds very good." (p. 17) "We could buy shares…" (p. 16) "My Richard was the eldest son of the eldest son" (p. 37)
Status, rivalry	"You tell them lah, they must show respect for their brother lah…" (p. 34) "What was Freddy's position?" (p. 36)
Kheong drifting away	"I expected the father to bring him to see the Headmaster" (p. 14) "But I send him special food from day to day" (p. 39) "I've had enough of his nonsense." (p. 40)
Rejection, vulnerability	"Kheong! Kheong! Which ward is he in?" (p. 43) "What do you mean, he doesn't want to see me…" (p. 44)
Change, letting go	"I don't forbid you to get married" (p. 48) "live your own life" (p. 48) · "make your own decisions" (p. 48) "I took his advice and sold the land" (p. 52)
Warmth in old age	"Well, how's your mother?" (p. 49) "…Mabel's children and Molly's children come to visit the old auntie" (p. 49)

> **ANALYSE ONE WORD**
> "you *better* listen" (p. 25): "better" sounds like a warning, not advice. It shows Emily expects obedience, so her relationship with Richard is one-sided.

Watch out: a quote with no comment earns little. Pick **one word** from it and say what it suggests.

How to write the essay question ESSAY

1. **Underline the key words** in the question (e.g. "how", "powerful", "to what extent")
2. **Plan for 5 minutes:** 3 points, each with a moment and a quote. Order them from beginning to end of Emily's life, or weakest to strongest
3. **Introduction** (2–3 lines): answer the question directly and name your 3 ideas
4. **3 body paragraphs** using **PEEL**: Point → Evidence (quote) → Explain (word choice + effect on the audience) → Link to the question
5. **Conclusion** (2–3 lines): your overall answer, plus what Kon wants the audience to think or feel

> **MODEL PARAGRAPH: "HOW DOES KON PRESENT EMILY AS A POWERFUL WOMAN?"**
> Kon shows that Emily's power comes from making others depend on her [point]. She sums up her own philosophy: a woman should be "the very devil of a wife and mother" [evidence]. The word "devil" suggests that Emily knows her methods are ruthless, yet she says it with pride, showing that power matters more to her than being liked [explain]. Since a woman in her world had value only as a wife and mother, she turns those roles into weapons [context]. This shows that Emily's power is real but built on control rather than love [link].

Watch out: marking is **holistic**: a clear argument that answers the question all the way through beats a long list of points. "To what extent" means give both sides, then a clear judgement.

Passage-based question: what makes it dramatic?

PASSAGE

The passage-based question has **2 parts** on a printed extract. One part is often about **style**: how Kon makes the passage **dramatic** (tense, gripping, moving for an audience).

DRAMATIC DEVICE	LOOK FOR	EFFECT ON THE AUDIENCE
Conflict and tension	Emily against someone (Kheong, Richard, in-laws)	we wait to see who wins
Sudden shifts in tone or mood	charming → angry, proud → hurt	surprise; shows her true feelings
Exclamations, rapid questions, repetition	"Kheong! Kheong! Which ward is he in?" (p. 43)	panic and urgency
Ellipsis, pauses	"he doesn't want to see me..." (p. 44)	shock; she can't finish the thought
Stage directions	*she laughs as Richard flatters her* (p. 5)	shows what words hide
Unseen characters, direct address	Emily answering people we can't hear	we fill the gaps and feel part of the scene
Dramatic irony	we see what Emily doesn't	pity, unease

1. Place the extract in one sentence: when it happens and what came just before
2. Read twice; underline 4–5 dramatic moments
3. Answer each part in PEEL paragraphs, taking quotes from the passage, in order
4. Label your answers **(i)** and **(ii)**, or marks are deducted

> **MODEL POINT**
> Kon makes the hospital scene dramatic through Emily's frantic questions, "Kheong! Kheong! Which ward is he in? Is he awake now?" (p. 43). The repeated name and rush of questions show her panic, so the audience feels the tension. This makes the next line, "he doesn't want to see me..." (p. 44), more shocking: the ellipsis shows she is too hurt to finish.

Watch out: "dramatic" doesn't mean "exciting events". Explain **how** Kon's choices create tension or emotion for an audience watching the play.

Last year's paper (2025): Section A and how it was marked

2025 EOY

The 2025 EOY paper in your resources folder, with the teachers' suggested answers. Expect questions like these.

1(a) Essay: “Emily is a powerless woman who has no freedom to make her own choices.” How far do you agree?

1. **Agree: society limits her.** Girls were burdens, valued only as wives and mothers: her mother's "useless girl" (pp. 44–45); "a woman must look after her husband" (p. 16)
2. **Disagree: she holds real power at home.** In a Peranakan matriarchy she runs Emerald Hill (pp. 16–17), controls Richard's friends and career (p. 5; pp. 24–25), Doris's dancing and reading (pp. 15, 17), and pressures Kheong over Diana (p. 42)
3. **Higher-ability: her choices become ambition.** Shares (p. 16), "Councillor Gan Joo Kheong" (p. 17), the grand dinners (pp. 19, 43), Richard's share of the property (p. 37)

Judgement: partly agree. Society limits women's choices, but Emily makes powerful choices within those limits, and later ones go beyond need.

Marking tip: good answers use quotes with context and explain the language. Weaker answers discuss only Emily, not the role of women overall.

1(b)(i) Passage-based (the first Chinese New Year, kneeling scene): What impressions do you form of Emily?

Manipulative: her father-in-law says they need not kneel, but she insists, "I want to kneel down", knowing it flatters him. Then "now you must kneel down to us, Kheong is your elder brother what" forces Joo Chong and Susie to kneel to her. *Higher-ability:* the stage directions call her "girlish" and like a "little girl"; the childlike act hides her real aim, claiming authority.

Socially skilled: her New Year wishes are tailored to each listener: "make another one million!" for her businessman father-in-law, grandchildren and "every game can sampai!" for her card-playing mother-in-law. "You must bring little Emily": others like her. She befriends the Methodist pastor: useful connections. *Higher-ability:* "Father, you see... You tell them lah": she uses her father-in-law's power to make the others obey.

Marking tip: stronger answers use stage directions as evidence and show Emily deliberately using family power dynamics to gain status.

1(b)(ii) Explore one other moment in the play that shows how Emily has changed in the later part of the play.

- **Talking to Doris (pp. 46–48):** more supportive; lets go of control; less manipulative
- **Accepting Kheong won't see her (p. 44):** no longer forcing her will; accepts the marriage has broken down
- **Talking to Susie (pp. 51–52):** stops treating her as competition
- **Taking Charlie's advice to sell (p. 52):** willing to accept others' input
- *Higher-ability:* forcing Kheong to give up Diana (p. 40): manipulation intensifies when her marriage, the base of her status, is at risk

Marking tip: pick ONE specific moment that is not in the passage, quote from it, and explain what has changed compared with the passage.

Watch out: for part (ii) the moment must come from **outside** the printed passage. Using the passage again scores nothing.

Practice questions on Emily

PRACTICE

What are your impressions of Emily in Act 1 and Act 2? (Essay)

Plan:

1. Act 1: commanding and organised: "So I keep myself busy, running the household" (p. 7); orders Ah Hoon; decides Richard's friendships (p. 6)
2. Act 2: controlling and strict as a mother: "Richard, you better listen to my advice." (p. 25); phones the riding school
3. Act 2: hurt, then changed: "What do you mean, he doesn’t want to see me..." (p. 44); "make your own decisions" (p. 48)

Conclusion: Emily moves from a woman who controls everyone to one who learns, through loss, to let go.

Marking tip: show change across the two acts, and support each impression with a quote and explanation.

How does Kon present the theme of motherhood? (Essay)

1. **Emily's own mother** rejected her as a useless daughter: a lack of love shapes her.
2. **Controlling love**: the London college (p. 17), "you will do everything that I want you to do" (p. 17), the riding school; the cost is Richard's death.
3. **Letting go**: Doris may "live your own life" (p. 48); Emily even arranges a home for her (p. 49).

Message: real motherly love means letting children choose.

Marking tip: compare Richard and Doris to show Kon's message, not just Emily's actions.

How does Kon present the role of women in society? (Essay)

1. **Limited choices**: married young; bullied by in-laws (p. 11); sons valued above daughters.
2. **Power through the home**: running the household (p. 7), hosting, status as the eldest son's wife (p. 34).
3. **Double standards and change**: Kheong's mistress versus Emily's duty (p. 39); Doris's free choices in America (p. 48).

Judgement: Emily is both limited by her society and skilled at using its rules.

Marking tip: a clear line of argument through the essay matters more than the number of points (holistic marking).

Explore the relationship between Emily and Kheong. (Essay)

Beginning: **distant but cordial**: he "couldn't be bothered" with the children (p. 14); "My husband didn't know" (p. 11).
End: **one-sided and strained**: she sends him food though he lives with his mistress (p. 39); "I've had enough of his nonsense" (p. 40); he refuses to see her in hospital (p. 44).

Marking tip: use precise adjectives and track how the relationship changes.

Passage-based (sample): How does Kon make this passage dramatic? (e.g. the hospital scene, pp. 43–44)

1. **Repetition and exclamations**: "Kheong! Kheong!" shows panic.
2. **Rapid questions**: "Which ward is he in? Is he awake now? Can I talk to him?" builds urgency.
3. **Sudden turn**: "What do you mean, he doesn't want to see me...": the ellipsis and the shock of rejection create pity.

Marking tip: name the device, quote the passage, then explain the effect on the audience; label each part (i) or (ii).

Watch out: these are plans. In the exam, turn each point into a full PEEL paragraph.

Unseen poetry

Section B · 4-Quadrant Routine, techniques, tone · 5 topics

The 4-Quadrant Routine (use for any poem)

METHOD

Your teachers' routine for making meaning of an unseen poem. Work round the four questions.

QUADRANT	MAIN QUESTION	SUB-QUESTIONS TO ASK
1. See details, patterns	What do you **SEE**?	What is happening? What is striking? What patterns (e.g. repetition) do you notice? What can you infer from the title? First impressions?
2. Mean significance, connections	What does this **MEAN** / **SHOW**?	What does the writer mean by…? Why is … significant? How does it make you think or feel? How are details, images and parts of the poem connected?
3. Writer's craft techniques, effects	**HOW** does the writer do this?	What literary techniques are used? What are their effects on you and the poem? How do they build the overall meaning?
4. Big idea overall meaning, themes	What is the **BIG IDEA**?	What is the poem about? What is the writer saying about human nature, society or the world? What do you think of it? How do your own experiences help you understand it?

See → Mean → How (craft) → Big idea

Watch out: don't stop at Quadrant 1 (describing). The marks are in Quadrants 2–4: meaning, effects and the big idea.

Poetry techniques and their effects

TECHNIQUES

TECHNIQUE	WHAT IT IS	EFFECT WORDS TO USE
Imagery	words that create a picture or sense	vivid, helps the reader see / hear / feel
Simile	comparison with "like" or "as"	emphasises a quality, makes it easy to picture
Metaphor	says one thing *is* another	stronger than a simile, gives new meaning
Personification	human qualities given to a thing	makes it seem alive, powerful or threatening
Alliteration	same first sound repeated	draws attention; hard sounds (k, c, t) feel harsh, soft sounds (s, m) feel gentle
Onomatopoeia	a word that sounds like its meaning	brings the scene alive through sound
Repetition	word or line repeated	emphasis, insistence, strong emotion
Rhyme and rhythm	sound pattern and beat	regular = calm, controlled; broken = tension
Enjambment	sentence runs over the line break	speed, flow, or an idea that can't be held back
Caesura	pause in the middle of a line (punctuation)	slows us down, stresses a word, hesitation
Contrast	two opposite ideas placed together	highlights a difference or a change
Symbol	object standing for an idea	adds deeper meaning (e.g. a bird for hope or freedom)

Watch out: "the poet uses alliteration" scores nothing on its own. Say **which words**, and what the sound or picture **makes the reader feel**.

Words for tone and mood

TONE

FEELING	TONE WORDS
Happy	joyful, celebratory, light-hearted, hopeful, admiring
Sad	melancholic, mournful, regretful, nostalgic, lonely
Angry	bitter, resentful, indignant, frustrated
Calm	peaceful, gentle, reflective, thoughtful

Fearful	anxious, tense, uneasy, threatening, ominous
Strong	confident, defiant, determined, proud
Mocking	sarcastic, ironic, humorous

- **Tone** = the speaker's attitude. **Mood** = the atmosphere the reader feels
- Describe a **shift**: "The tone changes from hopeful to regretful in stanza 3, when..."

Watch out: avoid vague words like "sad" or "happy" alone. Pick a precise word and back it up with a quote.

Structure and form

STRUCTURE

- **Stanzas:** how many, and does each one move the poem on (a new idea, time or feeling)?
- **Line length:** short lines are quick or abrupt; long lines are slow or flowing
- **Punctuation:** dashes, question marks and exclamations show hesitation, doubt or emotion
- **Opening and ending:** compare them. What has changed? Is the ending a surprise, a lesson or a question?
- **Free verse** (no regular rhyme or rhythm) can feel natural and like speech; a **regular pattern** can feel controlled or song-like

> **EXAMPLE SENTENCE**
> "The poem ends with a short, separate line, which makes the final image stand out and leaves the reader thinking about the speaker's loss."

Watch out: only write about structure if you can say its effect. Counting stanzas is not analysis.

Writing your poetry answer

ANSWERS

Section B is a **2-part question**, like WA3, marked holistically with the Lower Secondary Unseen Poetry band descriptors. Answer both parts and label them **(i)** and **(ii)**.

QUESTION TYPE	HOW TO ANSWER
"What do you learn about...?"	one point per mark, each with a short quote
"What is the effect of...?" / "Explain the image..."	name the technique, quote it, explain what it suggests and how it makes the reader feel
"How does the poet present...?" (longer)	3 PEEL paragraphs moving through the poem in order, including the tone shift and the ending

The 2025 questions were: (i) *What impressions do you form of [the relationship / speaker]?* and (ii) *In what ways does the poet use words and images strikingly?* Practise both types.

> **PEEL PARAGRAPH FRAME**
> The poet presents [idea] as [adjective] [point]. This is seen in "[short quote]" [evidence]. The word "[one word]" suggests... which makes the reader feel... [explain]. This shows that... [link to question].

Watch out: write in the present tense and about "the poet" or "the speaker", not "I think the poem is nice".

Poetry practice Section B · three poems with model answers · 4 topics

The Eagle (Tennyson)

POEM 1

> He clasps the crag with crooked hands;
> Close to the sun in lonely lands,
> Ring'd with the azure world, he stands.
>
> The wrinkled sea beneath him crawls;
> He watches from his mountain walls,
> And like a thunderbolt he falls.
>
> "The Eagle", Alfred, Lord Tennyson (1851)

What impressions of the eagle does the poet create in the first stanza?

The eagle seems **powerful and old**: "clasps" with "crooked hands" suggests a strong grip, like an old man's. It seems **isolated and noble**: "lonely lands" and "Close to the sun" show it lives high above everything, almost like a king.

Marking tip: two impressions, each supported with a quote and explained.

How does the poet use sound and imagery to make the eagle seem powerful?

The hard "c" alliteration in "clasps the crag with crooked hands" sounds harsh and gripping, matching the eagle's strength. Personification gives it "hands", making it seem almost human and in control. From its height, "The wrinkled sea beneath him crawls": the sea, normally mighty, seems small and weak, which shows how far above the world the eagle is. The simile "like a thunderbolt he falls" ends the poem with sudden, violent speed, showing its deadly power.

Marking tip: name each technique, quote it, then explain the effect. Three developed points beat six named techniques.

Comment on the structure of the poem.

Two stanzas of three lines, each with one rhyme sound (hands / lands / stands; crawls / walls / falls). The first stanza is still: the eagle "stands". The second ends in sudden movement: he "falls". This contrast between stillness and the final dive makes the ending dramatic.

Marking tip: link the structure to meaning: still → sudden action.

Watch out: "azure" means sky-blue. If you meet a word you don't know, work it out from context instead of skipping the line.

“Hope” is the thing with feathers (Dickinson)

POEM 2

"Hope" is the thing with feathers -
That perches in the soul -
And sings the tune without the words -
And never stops - at all -

And sweetest - in the Gale - is heard -
And sore must be the storm -
That could abash the little Bird
That kept so many warm -

I've heard it in the chillest land -
And on the strangest Sea -
Yet - never - in Extremity,
It asked a crumb - of me.

"Hope is the thing with feathers", Emily Dickinson (published 1891)

What is hope compared to, and why is this effective?

Hope is an extended **metaphor** for a small bird that "perches in the soul". A bird is small and light but keeps singing, which suggests hope is gentle yet always present inside us. It "sings the tune without the words": hope is a feeling we can't always explain.

Marking tip: identify the metaphor, then explain at least two ways the bird is like hope.

How does the poet show that hope is strong even in hard times?

"sweetest - in the Gale": hope sounds best during a storm, so it is strongest when life is hardest. "sore must be the storm / That could abash the little Bird" means only a terrible storm could silence it, stressing its toughness. It "kept so many warm", showing it comforts many people. Finally, it "never" asked "a crumb": hope gives everything and asks for nothing. The dashes slow the reader down and stress key words like "never".

Marking tip: move through the poem in order and include the ending; comment on the dashes for a structure point.

Describe the tone of the poem.

The tone is **hopeful and admiring**. The speaker praises hope gently, and in the last stanza becomes personal and grateful ("I've heard it").

Marking tip: a precise tone word, a quote, and a mention of the shift to the personal "I".

Watch out: stay with the metaphor. Every detail (feathers, singing, storm, crumb) is about hope, not a real bird.

Who Has Seen the Wind? (Rossetti)

POEM 3

> Who has seen the wind?
> Neither I nor you:
> But when the leaves hang trembling,
> The wind is passing through.
>
> Who has seen the wind?
> Neither you nor I:
> But when the trees bow down their heads,
> The wind is passing by.
>
> "Who Has Seen the Wind?", Christina Rossetti (1872)

What is the effect of the repeated question?

Repeating "Who has seen the wind?" at the start of each stanza makes the poem sound like a riddle or a song. The answer, "Neither I nor you", reminds us that the wind is invisible, so it makes the reader think about things we can't see but know are real.

Marking tip: explain both the sound effect (song or riddle) and the idea it raises.

How does the poet show the wind's presence even though it cannot be seen?

The poet shows the wind through its **effects**. Personification: "the leaves hang trembling" suggests the leaves are nervous or afraid, so the wind seems mysterious and powerful. "the trees bow down their heads" shows the trees bowing as if to a king, showing the wind's power and importance. The word "But" in both stanzas turns from what we can't see to what we can. The poem may suggest that unseen things such as love or faith can be known by their effects.

Marking tip: two developed points on personification, plus one on the wider meaning, scores well.

Watch out: a "deeper meaning" must come from the poem. Use "may suggest" and link it to words in the text.

Last year's poem (2025): “circles” by Angeline Yap

2025 EOY

The full poem is in the 2025 paper in your resources folder. Read it there first. **What it's about:** a toddler and her mother hug; the mother's arms seem to hold the child's whole world steady, and the poem links this embrace to the circling earth, sun and moon.

(i) What impressions do you form of the parent-child relationship in this poem?

1. **Deeply affectionate and close:** the toddler "reaching up enfolds" her mother's neck; the mother is "nuzzling the warmth"; "child and mother, face to face". The love goes both ways: "encircling, each, in her embrace"
2. **Secure and protective:** the mother's arms hold "the world, nor will she let it break"; "on its axis fixes it". She keeps the child's world steady and safe from things that might "spin amok"
3. **Mutually reassuring:** she shares "the trusted certainties of old", but "(or is she told?)" suggests the child comforts the mother too

Marking tip: other accepted words: trusting, very close, gentle (caring is weaker unless well supported). Each impression needs a quote and explanation.

(ii) In what ways does the poet use words and images strikingly?

- **Circle imagery:** "circles", "round", "curve", "encircling", "spins". It links a small hug to the huge, steady motion of the universe: a mother's love holds the child's world together
- **Metaphor:** the arms "pin our worlds in place" and fix the world "on its axis": like the earth's steady turning, the mother's embrace is constant and reliable
- **Simile and personification:** the earth "like a top, spins out her tune": a child's toy and a song make the universe feel playful and safe
- **Colourful nature imagery:** "dappled hues of love", "as is the peacock's tail", "rainbows and the greens of trees": beauty and joy in the relationship

Marking tip: name the device, quote it, and explain the effect and the feeling it creates. Three developed points beat a long list.

Watch out: "strikingly" means explain **why the image stands out** and what it makes you feel, not just name the technique.